

TOP PLAYER
RJD chief Lalu and Tejashwi (in white) at a party membership drive, Feb. 12

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WITH THE RJD MAKING NO CONCESSIONS IN THE RECENT POLLS, THE CONGRESS WAS FORCED TO TAKE ON ITS ALLY

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NO LOVE LOST

By Amitabh Srivastava

On February 10, as Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav addressed the party national executive in Patna, he underlined the party's centrality when it came to electoral alliances in the state. He promised to support the Congress on national issues but said it had to let the regional parties call the shots in the states. After more than two decades of a mutually beneficial friendship, the two parties are headed their separate ways.

There has been a decisive shift in RJD-Congress relations since the 2020 assembly election. Twice in the past four months, the RJD has dismissed its ally's demands on seat-sharing. In October 2021, the Congress broke away from the RJD and contested the bypolls held for the Kusheshwar Asthan and Tarapur seats. The ruling Janata Dal (United) won both. Again, now in February, the RJD has refused to accommodate the Congress in the upcoming polls for 24 legislative council (LC) seats, which are to be filled from local bodies' constituencies. The Congress has declared that it may contest all the seats on its own in the March-April election.

The RJD has its reasons for not complying. "If the RJD-led five-party Grand Alliance fell short of a majority in the 2020 assembly poll (it won 110 seats in the 243-member assembly, falling short by 10), it was largely because of the Congress, which contested 70 seats but won only 19," says a senior RJD leader in Patna.

RJD leaders privately admit that unlike Lalu, Tejashwi has little patience with the grand old party. On February 15, Lalu was handed his fifth conviction in as many fodder scam cases, which further supports the assessment that Tejashwi will remain in the driving seat in the party. Congress leaders, however, believe there is more to the RJD's new-found "impatience". "The RJD has hardened its stand since Kanhaiya Kumar's induction into the party, which has not gone down well with them," says a senior leader who did not want to be quoted. Kanhaiya, a former president of the Jawaharlal Nehru University students' union (JNUSU), is often described as a challenger to Tejashwi, the RJD's chief ministerial face.

RJD leaders, though, point to the Congress's thinning vote base. "Tejashwi wants to expand beyond the RJD's traditional Muslim-Yadav support base, which is possible only if he gives more tickets to OBC, EBC and upper caste leaders. So, instead of accommodating the Congress, we could use those seats to expand our social base," says an RJD leader. On February 13, when RJD candidates for 21 of the 24 LC seats came out, 10 were upper castes—five Bhumihar, four Rajputs and one Brahmin.

The Congress, too, is in revival mode. A digital membership drive is planned to double the number of active members, which is under 2 million now in Bihar. But it won't be easy. Over the years, the party's association with the RJD has pushed it to the state's political margins. Its traditional upper caste voters now prefer the NDA. The Congress challenge is clear: any ambitious bounceback plan without the RJD could leave it at the bottom of the electoral food chain. Right now, with 19 MLAs, it has the fourth largest tally in the state Vidhan Sabha. Going solo may erode these numbers, but it may be a risk worth taking for the party's long-term future in Bihar. ■